

NOTE FOR THE FILE

Meeting between Mr. Tom Fletcher, Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and Emergency Relief Coordinator and Humanitarian Coordinators

Virtual, 29 September 2025

Participants:

Mr. Tom Fletcher, USG for Humanitarian Affairs and Emergency Relief Coordinator (USG/ERC)

Ms. Joyce Msuya, ASG for Humanitarian Affairs and Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator (ASG/DERC)
Humanitarian Coordinators:

Mr. Indrika Ratwatte, Afghanistan; Mr. Maurice Azonnankpo, Burkina Faso (OIC); Mr. Issa Sanogo, Cameroon; Mr. Mohamed Ag Ayoya, CAR; Mr. François Batalingaya, Chad; Ms. Mireia Villar Forner, Colombia; Mr. Bruno Lemarquis, DRC; Ms. Nahla Valji, Eritrea; Mr. Imran Riza, Lebanon; Ms. Catherine Sozi, Mozambique; Mr. Michael Dunford, Myanmar (OIC); Ms. Mama Keita, Niger; Mr. Mohamed Fall, Nigeria; Mr. Mohamed Yahya, Pakistan; Mr. George Conway, Somalia; Ms. Anita Kiki Gbeho, South Sudan; Ms. Meritxell Relaño Arana, Syrian Arab Republic (OIC); Mr. Matthias Schmale, Ukraine; Mr. Gianluca Rampolla del Tindaro, Venezuela; Mr. Edward Kallon, Zimbabwe; Ms. Suzanna Tkalec, OPT (DHC); Mr. Antoine Gerard, Sudan (DHC)

Ms. Edem Wosornu, EDG Chair/Director, CRD, OCHA

Ms. Lisa Doughten, Director, FOD, OCHA

Mr. Ramesh Rajasingham, Director, HSD, OCHA

Mr. Rafael Sacal, Chief of Staff, OUSG, OCHA

Ms. Mervat Shelbaya, Chief, IASC Secretariat

Ms. Alice Armani Sequi, PFMB, OCHA

Ms. Gemma Connell, SBBP, OCHA

Ms. Sofie Garde Thomle, Director, IASC Peer-2-Peer Support, OCHA

Ms. Cindy Issac, Section Chief, HLSS, OCHA

Mr. Valijon Ranoev, HLSS, OCHA (note-taker)

Summary of discussions:

1. The USG/ERC opened the meeting with an overview of the UN High-Level Week, summarizing key senior leadership engagements with a focus on Gaza, Sudan, Syria, and Ukraine. On UN80, he noted broad Member State support and referred HCs to the recently published UN80 report on Workstream 3. On the Humanitarian Reset, he highlighted strong backing from Member States, many of whom are urging the system to “go further and faster”. On the US funding, the USG/ERC noted good steps during the week, with conversations moving from what the US will not do to what they can potentially do.
2. The USG/ERC recognized progress made since February – protecting humanitarian space, simplifying coordination, leading transitions, and advancing localisation – and reiterated his message that the HCs have the license to go even further to deliver change that best fits their contexts.
3. In this regard, the USG/ERC highlighted HC leadership on the following issues as critical: (a) **prioritized appeals and plans** that clearly define the scope of the humanitarian crisis, focus on the most severe needs and protection risks, reflect the priorities of affected communities, and bring L/NGOs into the process; (b) **context-specific coordination**, streamlining or adapting structures, including clusters, to local realities, while safeguarding humanitarian principles and ensuring that independent humanitarian action is not merged with development action; (c) **shifting power and resources to local actors**, including women-led organizations, by ensuring meaningful representation in HCTs, co-leadership of clusters, and humanitarian action being directly informed by crises-affected people's priorities; and (d) the **strategic use of pooled funds** to deliver on the above, including significantly increasing the share channelled to local and national actors, and communicating on resulting changes/impact to counter perceptions on the Reset not advancing fast enough.

4. The USG/ERC shed light on ongoing efforts to empower HCs, including by providing political cover, strengthening HC–HCT two-way accountability, simplifying clusters and supporting area-based coordination, and driving increased cash programming, including related support by the pooled funds. He urged HCs and HCTs to push for locally-led responses at the country level, backed by the IASC at the global level. The ERC also underlined the Deputy SG and his commitment to do more on developing shared performance evaluations as part of the UN80 Shared Platform Initiative.
5. The USG/ERC also encouraged HCs and HCTs to show concrete examples of Reset implementation through storytelling and communications to counter scepticism and resistance inside and outside the system. He invited HCs to share context-specific progress, challenges, and support needs for implementing the Reset. This will also help to inform the IASC Principals discussions on 28 October as well as shape next steps under the Reset¹.
6. **Mozambique:** The HC reported on shifting coordination from Maputo to Pemba, and advancing locally-led response, with 100 per cent of the Humanitarian Fund allocated to national NGOs. She noted challenges with government capacity to lead coordination. **Cameroon:** The HC underlined that an HCT-validated vision on the transition is guiding Area Based Coordination (ABC) and resource mobilization, but government ownership and sector coordination as well as protection risks remain a challenge. Despite hyper-prioritization, funding remains significantly less than previous years. He requested USG/ERC and IASC support on localization, noting that humanitarian principles may not always be fully upheld—a concern echoed by other participants.
7. **DRC:** The HC reported Reset implementation underway and requested OCHA support to engage Cluster Lead Agencies to address reduced coordination capacity. He emphasized the humanitarian community’s authority and role in prevention and risk mitigation, especially given the current financial climate. **South Sudan:** The HC noted the response plan target and funding requirements had been reduced, while 50 per cent of pooled fund allocations are going to local NGOs. Progress was reported on cluster mergers, ABC, and nexus coordination. She called for advocacy with donors on shifting the narrative that providing development funding in fragile contexts inadvertently reinforces behaviours.
8. **Colombia:** The HC outlined challenges on the volatile political and security context. She noted progress on a detailed Reset implementation plan and highlighted worrying funding trends and the need to get ahead donor funding allocations. Pooled funding and clusters are areas where she suggested further conversation, noting the language on empowering HCs is often contradicted by the need to repeatedly “check-in” at the HQ level before moving ahead. She also voiced concerns that nationalization of clusters may lead to needs not being represented within the GHO.
9. **Myanmar:** The HC OiC stressed the need for streamlined OCHA–DCO coordination, and greater engagement with Gulf States for resource mobilization. **Pakistan:** The HC highlighted the value of CERF and pooled funds in natural disaster response, with 100 per cent of allocations directed to local actors. He requested clarity on support and capacity from 2026 onward given heightened monsoon risks and stressed the importance of OCHA’s regional support from Bangkok.
10. **Afghanistan:** The HC reported on cluster transition efforts to a common platform and ABC progress. He highlighted challenges with regards to boundary setting as part of response planning and defining needs. He requested support to ensure clarity on common platforms, noting that a humanitarian donor recently raised concerns about diluting humanitarian principles while working in a more joined manner, rather than viewing this as a continuum of resilience/stability effort. **Lebanon:** The HC stressed the need to shift toward development but noted donor funding gaps in supporting localization and NGO capacity-building.

¹There was an overall convergence of views on many of the issues. Therefore, this note does not capture every example and challenges raised by HCs.

He underlined the need for adequate staffing to manage pooled funds. He noted that the latest allocation is targeting 70 per cent to national NGOs.

11. **Chad:** The HC requested support in establishing ABC across different zones, clarity on Global Cluster Lead support, and highlighted the need for stronger humanitarian–development links. He also called for high level coordination between OCHA and UNHCR that involve HCs on the mixed settings model. **CAR:** The HC reported good progress on decentralized coordination under the leadership of the government, with support in terms of capacity and mobility. A Reset Committee has been set up which includes government and local communities. He highlighted an increase in local NGO allocations (6 per cent in 2022 to 36 per cent in 2025).
12. **Nigeria:** The HC requested clearer understanding of Reset expectations among partners at the country level. He also noted resistance from the humanitarian community to engage with development partners. On Anticipatory Action (AA), he shared a recent initiative that reached 350,000 people with government engagement as a good example of collaboration and bottom-up approach to reducing needs. **Niger:** The HC echoed AA, prevention, and nexus approaches as efficient tools to reduce needs, but flagged rising security risks and funding challenges.
13. **Burkina Faso:** The HC OiC reported on coordination simplification discussions and sought guidance on government engagement given the challenges in the country. He noted progress on localization (50 per cent of HRP partners are national, 30 per cent of funding to local NGOs) but flagged challenges with access to funds linked to compliance and risk management. **Syria:** The HC OiC highlighted national NGO interest in leadership roles despite resistance from ministers. She confirmed the transition to “One Syria” architecture is complete, with other Reset elements pending new leadership. **Venezuela:** The HC stressed urgent humanitarian diplomacy to address the deepening crisis and shrinking civic space, calling for mobilization across humanitarian, human rights, and political actors to support de-escalation.
14. **The ASG/DERC** highlighted ongoing OCHA–DCO work to strengthen coordination. She also stressed the importance of direct feedback from country operations and encouraged HCs to maintain this feedback channel to inform global discussions.
15. **The USG/ERC** reaffirmed his commitment to provide additional support, including issuing follow up guidance to strengthen HC roles within HCTs. On expectations by partners at the country level, the USG/ERC noted that he is having conversations with the IASC Principals on assessing country representatives on how well they are able to coordinate and work with HCs and together as an HCT, including to drive Reset related change. On humanitarian diplomacy, USG/ERC was looking to put more energy and build on the work already underway as part of the Humanitarian Cluster under the UN80. He also committed to engaging bilaterally with HCs on humanitarian diplomacy. He acknowledged the need to understand and adapt to the risks as they emerge to push forward with localisation. On the future of data, the USG/ERC noted that this would be reviewed at the IASC and OCHA levels.
16. On pooled funds, **FOD Director** noted that more than 60 per cent of pooled funds were currently allocated to local and national partners. She also noted that while the global guidelines were currently being revised, there is an agreement with donors to continue to innovate. **The CRD Director** stressed her full support to HCs in addressing the challenges raised in the call and beyond. She also acknowledged the challenges and risks and reiterated the need to strike the right balance between handing over to government and preserving humanitarian principles. **The HSD Director** acknowledged the reduced coordination capacity across contexts and offered support to address this, while noting expected reduction in funding going forward.

Action points:

Action point Capture existing good practice on Reset implementation
Assigned to: IASC Secretariat, in consultation with HCs
Responsible Office: IASC Secretariat
Deadline: Immediate

Action point Report back on the progress on the Shared Platform as part of UN80,
Assigned to: HLSS
Responsible Office: HLSS
Deadline: 20 December 2025

Action point Share feedback to relevant HCs in transition countries following the
meeting between OCHA and DSG.
Assigned to: SPPB
Responsible Office: SPPB
Deadline: By 15 December 2025

Action point Capture where development support is pulling out. Take up the issue
with the Joint Steering Committee.
Assigned to: SPPB
Responsible Office: SPPB
Deadline: By 31 October 2025

Action point Share the 10 immediate actions for Country/Regional Pooled Funds to
advance the Reset and offer a session to discuss challenges and
opportunities to move forward.
Assigned to: PFB
Responsible Office: PFB
Deadline: Immediate

[Valijon Ranoev/HLSS/OUSG]
[2 October 2025]